



Slow belonging and affective rupture: youth reconfigurations of home in post-urban Vietnam

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Affective migration
Post-urban youth
Belonging as becoming
Slow life practices
Rural experimentation

ABSTRACT

This paper explores the phenomenon of young urban dwellers in contemporary Vietnam voluntarily relocating to rural farms as a form of affective life-making rather than economic migration or return. Drawing on narrative ethnographic data from two farm communities in mountainous areas in Gia Lai and Da Lat, the study conceptualizes these urban-to-rural transitions as aspirational reorientations shaped by emotional exhaustion, familial disconnection, and desires for a slower, more meaningful life. Building on de Haas's aspiration-capabilities framework and Antonsich's notion of belonging as becoming, the analysis frames rural relocation as a dynamic process of negotiating aspirations, enacting affective labor, and experimenting with new modes of belonging. Practices such as caregiving, storytelling, and slow daily routines emerge as strategies to reclaim agency and reconfigure selfhood outside normative urban trajectories. These affective strategies reflect broader emotional realignments that underpin youth disengagement from dominant urban futures. The paper contributes to emerging debates on post-growth youth mobility and affective geographies by centering the emotional logics that underlie voluntary rural transitions in the Global South.

1. Introduction

In recent years, a quiet shift has emerged in Vietnam's youth mobility landscape. While urban migration remains dominant, a countercurrent has gained traction: educated young people voluntarily moving to rural spaces, farms, eco-villages, and homestays, not for economic gain or familial return, but to seek emotional clarity and alternative modes of living. We distinguish these moves from classic return migration: rather than a biographical "going back" to one's place of origin, participants relocate out of cities toward smaller rural settings to craft slower, more livable lives. This both aligns with and provincializes global lifestyle and amenity migration debates by foregrounding affect, care, and Southeast Asian conditions (Benson, 2016; Benson and O'Reilly, 2016; Osbaldiston et al., 2020).

Comparable shifts have also been noted elsewhere, where youth are drawn to rurality not as regression but as possibility (Klien, 2022; Cuervo and Wyn, 2017). Scholars of "slow" and voluntary simplicity interpret such moves as practices of refusal and reorientation, where individuals experiment with slower rhythms, reduced consumption, and relational belonging (Parkins and Craig, 2006; Osbaldiston, 2013; Hook

et al., 2023). Comparative cases such as the CittàSlow movement further show how slowness is articulated as both policy and everyday ethic (Servon and Pink, 2015; Özcan Alp, 2024). These relocations challenge the idea of return as closure and instead frame mobility as ongoing self-reinvention (Schewel, 2020; Wang and Chen, 2021).

In Vietnam, however, academic attention has lagged. Studies often reduce such moves to economic retreat or COVID-induced disruption, overlooking their affective and ontological dimensions. Yet research on rural youth aspirations in the Mekong Delta and comparative work in Indonesia highlight how rural aspirations intertwine with land, education, and intergenerational obligations (Coleman et al., 2025; Clendenning, 2023). Situating Vietnam's counter-urban youth within these Southeast Asian dynamics underscores that aspirations to slow are not mere lifestyle choices but affectively charged negotiations of precarity and possibility.

Contemporary migration theory increasingly acknowledges the role of aspirations (Carling and Collins, 2020; de Haas, 2021), yet it seldom interrogates their affective texture. This is particularly salient in Global South contexts, where voluntary rural relocation is rarely analyzed as emotional refusal or existential recalibration. Participants in this study

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<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.emospa.2025.101128>

Received 24 May 2025; Received in revised form 1 October 2025; Accepted 12 October 2025

Available online 15 October 2025

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are not seeking stability but inhabiting what [Klien \(2022\)](#) describes as a heterotopic condition—marked by ambiguity, precarity, and experimentation with alternative ways of living. Such movement requires engagement with affective geographies, where space, sensation, and agency intertwine to forge alternative futures ([Davidson and Milligan, 2004](#); [Glaveanu and Womersley, 2021](#)). Belonging here is not fixed attachment but an unfolding process of becoming—what [Probyn \(1996\)](#) describes as restless desire and [Antonsich \(2010\)](#) conceptualizes as dynamic negotiation across emotional, spatial, and relational terrains. Rather than “returning home,” these young urbanites inhabit rural spaces in Gia Lai and Da Lat as provisional zones of transformation, where rupture from urban life opens possibilities for reorientation. We argue that these migrations are not economic retreats or escapist gestures, but intentional refusals: emotionally charged acts of reclaiming autonomy through caregiving, slow work, and communal living, enabled by intersectional privileges of class, gender, and education. This inquiry is guided by the following research questions:

- What forms of crisis or aspiration motivate young people to leave urban environments for rural farms?
- How do these individuals negotiate new ways of being and belonging through everyday practices in rural life?
- In what ways does the concept of “belonging as becoming” illuminate their experiences of movement, stasis, and self-construction?

2. Literature review

2.1. Aspirations to slow: youth counter-urban moves

In late modernity, urban youth navigate precarious lifeworlds marked by affective exhaustion, professional volatility, housing precarity, and fragmented kinship networks. These dynamics echo [Bauman's \(2000\)](#) “liquid modernity,” where identities and attachments are unstable, and contribute to what [Hart \(2016\)](#) and [Carling and Collins \(2020\)](#) term a broader “crisis of futurity.” For many, aspirations become difficult to sustain, and linear life paths lose coherence. As [Standing \(2011\)](#) notes, the rise of the “precarariat” erodes middle-class security, making conventional urban success scripts unattainable. We frame a clear chain: urban precarity generates affective rupture, which crystallizes aspirations to slow and cohere. Youth thus turn to rural spaces not as nostalgic refuges or economic fallback, but as sites of experimentation and recalibration—affect-suffused projects to re-tempo work, time, and care ([Davidson and Milligan, 2004](#); [Glaveanu and Womersley, 2021](#)).

Rather than treating rural relocation as retreat, scholars highlight its affective and ethical orientations. [Halfacree \(2014\)](#) conceptualizes counter-urbanisation as embodied resistance to neoliberal individualism, while [Benson and O'Reilly \(2009\)](#) interpret lifestyle migration as a search for authenticity, simplicity, and connection beyond consumerist ideals. [Klien's \(2022\)](#) ethnography of rural Japan conceptualizes relocation as a heterotopic practice, where urban migrants navigate insecurity, aspiration, and hope while reworking their sense of self and belonging. Such moves are not quests for permanence but iterative life-making ([Schewel, 2020](#)), provisional and deliberately indeterminate.

This reframing positions mobility as disposition rather than destination: a refusal of linear futurity and a turn toward present-tense living. [Glaveanu and Womersley's \(2021\)](#) concept of “affective mobilities” captures how such movements are propelled less by rational calculation than by longings to slow down or feel otherwise. Emotional rupture thus becomes the catalyst for counter-urban experimentation, while voluntary relocation emerges as a capability-conditioned practice of slowness—an attempt to recompose existential and emotional grammars. As [Pimlott-Wilson \(2017\)](#) reminds us, aspirations are structured not only by material opportunity but by emotional needs to feel safe, seen, or free.

2.2. Counter-urban youth: lifestyle, amenities, and slowness

Conventional migration theory often adheres to a linear model of movement, origin, departure, destination, and eventual return. This model frames “return migration” as a narrative closure, assuming a pre-existing home to which one belongs. We reserve return migration for cases of biographical “going back” to one's place of origin; our participants predominantly undertake counter-urban/ex-urban moves to new rural localities.

This reframing aligns with lifestyle migration scholarship—especially “lifestyle-in-migration,” where lifestyles are made through mobility and are suffused with emotional reflexivity ([Benson, 2016](#); [Benson and O'Reilly, 2016](#); [Osbaldeston et al., 2020](#)). Rather than “going back,” these movers pursue alternative futures by “moving forward differently,” treating rural or peripheral spaces as horizons for becoming where normative scripts of permanence and accumulation are deliberately suspended ([Torkington, 2012](#)).

[Schewel's \(2020\)](#) concept of “emergent subjectivity” further highlights mobility as an ongoing reconfiguration of values, relationships, and temporalities, while [Boccagni and Brighenti \(2017\)](#) frame dwelling as a socio-material project of negotiating personhood and belonging. Amenity migration studies contribute a comparative lens, pointing to the attraction of landscapes, cultural amenities, and everyday rhythms ([Gosnell and Abrams, 2011](#)), while the *CittàSlow* movement illustrates how slowness becomes institutionalized in collective life ([Servon and Pink, 2015](#); [Özcan Alp, 2024](#)).

Yet, in the Vietnamese context, these moves hinge less on sustainability branding than on affective rupture, kinship obligations, and informal economies. They are contingent, emotionally situated, and exemplify what [Glaveanu and Womersley \(2021\)](#) term “affective mobilities,” where emotion is a structuring force of movement. Such relocations are therefore best understood not as escapes or fallbacks, but as affective refusals—deliberate rejections of urban scripts of ambition, productivity, and linear futurity. For clarity, we use counter-urban or ex-urban throughout this paper to distinguish these youth-led moves from classic return migration.

2.3. Aspirations—capabilities with affective texture: refusing urban scripts through slowness

Contemporary migration cannot be explained by structural constraints or economic incentives alone; it requires attention to the intersection of desire and capacity. [De Haas's \(2011\)](#) aspiration–capability framework reconceptualizes migration as shaped by what individuals hope for and what they are able to achieve, shifting focus from necessity to the interplay between agency and constraint. Aspirations, in this view, are not fixed preferences but socially embedded, emotionally saturated, and reconfigured through experience ([Carling and Collins, 2020](#)).

We extend this framework by conceptualizing aspirations as affect-saturated—emerging from burnout, moral unease, and relational rupture—and realized only where capabilities (classed, gendered, educational) enable practices of slowness. Migration here is not just spatial relocation but an imaginative response to temporal misalignment and emotional urgency ([Wang and Chen, 2021](#)). Rural moves embody what [Parkins and Craig \(2006\)](#) and [Osbaldeston \(2013\)](#) describe as practices of voluntary simplicity—recalibrations of consumption, rhythm, and care. Systematic reviews confirm that voluntary simplicity links to well-being and environmental concern, showing “slowness” as enacted dispositions rather than a slogan ([Hook et al., 2023](#)).

For young urbanites in Vietnam, such moves are rarely driven by unlimited privilege; they depend on intersectional advantages of education, class, and gendered expectations that shape who can “refuse” urban scripts and sustain slower lives. [Schewel's \(2020\)](#) notion of life-making strengthens this perspective, framing mobility as an experiment in meaning-making when normative scripts falter.

Rural relocation therefore emerges not as retreat but as experimentation—a reconfiguration of what counts as success, worth, or stability. As Hart (2016) notes, aspirations may express ethical dissensus: the pursuit of stillness over acceleration, care over accumulation, slowness over ambition. In this way, youth migration embodies a project of temporal and affective recalibration, enabled through capabilities yet driven by affective rupture, lived as ongoing experiments in “slow belonging.”

2.4. *Belonging-as-becoming through practices of slowness: experimental rurality*

Recent scholarship has moved away from essentialist notions of belonging, emphasizing relational, fluid, and emotionally situated frameworks. Antonsich (2010) conceptualizes belonging as a constellation of ties, practices, and discursive positioning rather than fixed attachment. Building on this, Klien and Reiher (2025) highlight how mobilities function not only as career strategies but also as ways to navigate multiple belongings and manage risks, underscoring belonging as affectively charged and dynamically negotiated within transitional or ambiguous geographies.

Probyn (1996) similarly frames belonging as never fully attained but always in process—a restless becoming rather than stable resolution. For young migrants, rural relocation is less about returning to origins than about iterative self-construction through the unfamiliar. Klien's (2022) ethnography of rural Japan frames urban migrants as inhabiting heterotopic conditions—spaces of ambiguity, precarity, and experimentation—where aspirations, risks, and alternative practices of living are negotiated in tension with local norms. This aligns with Benson and O'Reilly (2016) “lifestyle-in-migration,” where lifestyle and belonging emerge through migration itself, and with Schewel's (2020) framing of life-making as an open-ended reconfiguration of values and viability.

In this perspective, rural space functions less as settlement than as provisional terrain for becoming, marked by improvisation and affective experimentation. This challenges typologies such as “returnee” or “settler” by foregrounding embodied practices and emotional negotiations through which belonging is lived. Halfacree's (2014) critique—that rural spaces are often marked by agribusiness or drudgery rather than idylls—resonates with the Vietnamese case, where sustaining rural life hinges on mobilizing capabilities and emotional aspirations rather than retreating to an imagined pastoral. The ambiguity of being neither fully home nor fully elsewhere thus becomes a generative condition for narrative and emotional recalibration (Davidson and Milligan, 2004; Glaveanu and Womersley, 2021).

2.5. *Regionalizing lifestyle/amenity debates: Vietnam & Southeast Asia*

Recent Southeast Asian research complicates conventional framings. In Indonesia, studies show how rural futures are entangled with land tenure, education, and intergenerational obligations (Clendenning, 2023). These dynamics underscore how affective aspirations are inseparable from moral-material conditions. Comparative analogies, such as CittàSlow (Servon and Pink, 2015; Özcan Alp, 2024), illustrate how slowness can be institutionalized, yet Southeast Asian counter-urban youth negotiate it through land access, kinship, and informal economies—rendering “slow” more a lived ethic than a policy framework.

Vietnam is witnessing a subtle shift in the life trajectories of urban-educated youth who voluntarily relocate to rural farms, homestays, or eco-retreats, popularly captured by the phrase *bỏ phố về rừng* (“leaving the city for the forest”). Yet, while socially visible, these movements remain under-theorized. Most migration scholarship in Vietnam has centered on rural–urban or rural–rural flows (Nguyen, 2021), labor mobility (Anh, 2006), transnational workers (Bélanger et al., 2011), and remittances (Amare and Hohfeld, 2016), with urban-to-rural mobility often treated as return migration driven by duty, retirement, or fallback (Hoang et al., 2015). Studies in the Mekong Delta and central Vietnam

(Coleman et al., 2025; Nhat et al., 2025) further show how rural futures are shaped by structural obligations, yet Vietnamese counter-urban youth remain absent from such debates. Their moves are still framed as idiosyncratic or crisis-driven rather than part of generational negotiations with precarity. This risks conflating youth life-making with economic fallback, overlooking how disaffiliation from urban burnout and the search for coherence animate such moves.

Our analysis instead traces participants' storylines across departure and relocation, extending narrative approaches to belonging (Probyn, 1996; Antonsich, 2010) to show how urban ruptures are re-aligned through rural practices of slowness. This highlights a clear research gap: little work positions Vietnam's counter-urban youth at the intersection of affect, slowness, and capability. Our study addresses this by provincializing lifestyle/amenity debates, situating Vietnamese narratives within both local socio-material conditions and broader Southeast Asian contexts.

3. Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative design grounded in ethnographic fieldwork and narrative inquiry to examine the experiences of young urban Vietnamese who voluntarily relocate to rural spaces in search of alternative ways of life. Our methodological orientation is best described as narrative ethnography (Czarniawska, 2004; Clandinin and Connelly, 2000), which combines an interpretivist/constructivist stance with the analytic treatment of storytelling as both method and object of inquiry. We view stories as situated performances through which identities are (re)made under conditions of urban precarity. Accordingly, participants were invited to narrate life histories not as linear trajectories but as affective episodes—turning points, crises, and moments of contemplation—through which they made sense of mobility, belonging, and aspiration. This approach assumes that identity is continuously negotiated through stories in transitional contexts of social dislocation and self-reinvention (Riessman, 2008).

3.1. *Research setting*

Fieldwork was conducted across two community farms in Gia Lai province and a homestay site in Da Lat, with visits spanning multiple seasons between 2019, 2023 and 2025. In total, one of us conducted six field visits: a 20-day stay at the Da Lat homestay in March–April 2021; two extended stays at Gia Lai Farm 1 (eight weeks in late 2023 and one week in March 2025); shorter return visits with follow-up interviews in Hanoi in 2023–2024; and a 10-day stay at Gia Lai Farm 2 in March 2025. Each site functioned as a semi-communal setting of small-scale agriculture, homestay hospitality, and collective labor (shared meals, maintenance, gardening, guest work), typically hosting 5–10 young residents and volunteers. These immersive contexts provided dense opportunities to observe “slowness practices” in everyday routines, from pacing of farm work to shared cooking and care. These sites were selected for their accessibility to young adults seeking lifestyle change and for their functioning as semi-communal spaces of alternative living, labor, and sociality.

3.2. *Participants and sampling*

Inclusion criteria required participants to be young adults (aged 26–39 at the time of fieldwork) with at least three years of urban education or work experience in cities such as Ho Chi Minh City, Hanoi, Quy Nhon, or Binh Duong, and who had relocated to rural sites for longer-term stays (≥ 3 months) as part of lifestyle change. Short tourist visits of less than three weeks were excluded. Moves were classified as counter-urban rather than return migration, unless the rural site overlapped directly with a participant's birthplace.

The final sample comprised seven individuals (six women and one man) whose relocations were driven not by economic necessity but by

affective rupture, disillusionment, or existential unease. Their backgrounds included former professionals (a government officer, a medical worker, a marketing employee), as well as factory and office workers, each negotiating different forms of disengagement from urban scripts of success, productivity, and heteronormativity.

Importantly, none of the participants had returned to their natal village. Only one case (Thao) resided near her extended family's province, but not in her birthplace, and thus her move is still treated analytically as counter-urban. This distinction aligns with our broader framing of these relocations as aspirational and affective rather than nostalgic or biographical "returns."

Participants' current rural engagements spanned homestay ownership and co-management, casual volunteering, seasonal returns, and land stewardship. Their transitions revealed diverse tempos and intentions—ranging from indefinite settlement to cyclical mobility—underscoring the contingent and processual character of rural life-making. See Table 1 for an overview of participants' demographics, urban backgrounds, motivations, and current rural engagements.

3.3. Data collection

We conducted 14 in-depth interviews with seven participants (one to three per person, including follow-ups), typically lasting 90–150 min. Interviews were conducted primarily in Vietnamese, mostly face-to-face during field stays, with some follow-up sessions in Hanoi in 2023–2024. All but one interview were audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim. Core prompts included (English translations):

"Tell me about the moment you decided to leave the city."

"Before leaving, what was the pace of your life and your relationships like?"

"After moving to the farm, how have you slowed down in terms of work, time, consumption, or care?"

"In what ways did family, gender, or class enable or constrain this move?"

"Do you plan to return to the city or move elsewhere—and why?"

(These are translated from the original Vietnamese prompts)

Interviews were complemented by more than 300 h of participant observation across four field visits in Da Lat and Gia Lai (2021, 2023, 2025). One of us lived with participants in homestays and farms, joining in daily activities such as cooking, gardening, welcoming guests, cleaning, and shared leisure. Jottings and expanded fieldnotes documented tempo, labor rhythms, and affective atmospheres of community life. Audio files were encrypted; transcripts were anonymized and organized in secure digital folders for systematic coding. Thematic

coding was conducted manually using iterative reading and memo writing. Vietnamese–English translation followed a translate–review–back-check procedure to ensure accuracy for quoted excerpts.

3.4. Data analysis

We followed an iterative narrative–thematic pipeline informed by Braun and Clarke (2006). First, transcripts and fieldnotes were read repeatedly with memoing of affective events. In the first coding cycle, we used in-vivo and event codes. In the second cycle, codes were grouped into patterns and assembled into broader storylines and cross-case themes. Themes were then reviewed and named in dialogue with literatures on lifestyle/amenity migration and slow/voluntary simplicity. To render the temporal arcs, we produced analytic vignettes highlighting participants' pre-migration ruptures and post-migration practices of slowness.

In analyzing these storylines, we attended closely to affective cues such as tone, hesitation, metaphors, and embodied expressions, treating them as analytically central rather than supplementary. This approach extends narrative perspectives on belonging (Probyn, 1996; Antonsich, 2010) and responds to calls for deeper narrative analysis by foregrounding the tacit dimensions of participants' transitions and the contingent ways they articulated reasons for leaving the city, staying at the farm, or moving again.

3.5. Ethical consideration

One of us is a PhD student in anthropology from northern Vietnam, responsible for fieldwork and data collection; the other is a researcher based in southern Vietnam, focused on data analysis, conceptual framing, and writing. Our positionalities—shaped by age, gender, disciplinary training, and regional location—influenced both access and interpretation. To avoid projection or romanticization of "slowness," we maintained reflexive memos on language, power asymmetries, and expectations throughout fieldwork.

Our analysis highlights how education, class-based safety nets, and gendered care norms shaped participants' ability to refuse urban scripts and sustain rural experiments. While not all youth could afford to leave the city or persist in precarious rural ventures, some sustained themselves through low-paid but emotionally fulfilling rural work, supported by lower living costs and stronger social ties. These moves emphasized affective sufficiency over financial maximization, resonating with Benson's (2016) focus on lived experience beyond economic calculus. At the same time, participants' capacity to pursue "slower" practices was

Table 1
Participant overview and motivations for rural relocation.

No.	Pseudonym	Year of Birth	Previous Urban Life	Motivation for Leaving City	Current Rural Role	Duration of Stay	Future Plan
1	Vinh	1986	Government officer in Quy Nhon, former migrant worker in Japan	Divorce, emotional exhaustion, disillusionment with urban career	Café bartender, informal supporter at farm	2 months (at time of interview)	No fixed plan; staying as long as it feels peaceful
2	Ha	1997	Former factory worker in Binh Duong and various cities post-divorce	Burnout, relationship trauma, desire to "reset"	Housekeeping manager at farm; oversees volunteers	Over 1 year	Long-term stay if emotional stability continues
3	Suong	1997	Office worker in Ho Chi Minh, intermittent volunteer	Need for escape, self-reconnection, fatigue with city pace	Flexible volunteer, light farm duties, lifestyle-based short stays	On and off since 2023	Will return annually; not a full-time resident
4	Du	1992	Medical professional in Ho Chi Minh	Existential dissatisfaction, pursuit of autonomy, self-realization	Owner-manager of rural homestay	Since 2015	Settled but continues to travel frequently
5	Ninh	~1992	Marketing employee in Ho Chi Minh	Desire for authentic living and spiritual growth	Co-manager of homestay, social media branding	Since 2018	Permanent cohabitation and business with Du
6	Ly	1996	Volunteer then manager post-FTU graduation	Professional stagnation, curiosity about "alternative life"	Temporary manager; left after conflict and burnout	~1 year (2016–2017)	Returned to urban life; does not plan to return permanently
7	Thao	1992	High-paid urban professional (NEU Hanoi)	Family pressure to marry, desire for solitude	Landowner and solo dweller in mountain retreat	Since ~2022	Plans to stay but may relocate again for travel

enabled by cultural and social capital (Bourdieu, 1986), motivating their departure from the city and supporting continuity in rural life. This intersectional lens extends the aspiration–capability framework by situating affective motivations within broader structures of possibility and constraint.

All participants were fully informed of the research aims and gave verbal consent, sometimes confirmed via written messages. Narratives were anonymized with pseudonyms, while audio files and fieldnotes were securely stored. Translated excerpts followed a translate–review–back-check process to ensure accuracy. Trustworthiness was strengthened through triangulation of interviews and field observations, peer debriefing between researchers, and selective member-checking, where short vignettes were returned to participants for factual resonance. The study complied with institutional ethical guidelines and prioritized participants' autonomy, privacy, and affective wellbeing.

3.6. Scope and limitations

This study does not aim for statistical generalizability. Instead, it seeks theoretical transferability (Lincoln and Guba, 1985) by providing thick, situated narratives that illuminate broader affective and aspirational dynamics of post-urban youth mobility in Vietnam. The small sample size and geographically bounded sites mean that findings reflect the specificities of community farms and homestays in Gia Lai and Da Lat rather than the diversity of rural Vietnam as a whole. The longitudinal dimension of the fieldwork—spanning repeated visits between 2021 and 2025—offers temporal depth but remains limited in scope; participants' stories capture moments of transition rather than entire life courses. Moreover, translation from Vietnamese to English, even with a translate–review–back-check process, may smooth over subtle tonalities and embodied nuance. We therefore position the findings as theoretically generative rather than statistically representative. The value lies in tracing how affective ruptures and aspirations for slowness are narratively re-aligned through rural practices, offering insight into wider debates on lifestyle migration, belonging, and youth precarity, while acknowledging the partiality of the sample and the interpretive work of the researchers.

4. Findings

4.1. “I don't know where I'm going, but I know I can't stay”: leaving the city as refusal of structure

The departure from urban life, for many participants in this study, was not drawn by rural charm, but driven by an urgent disaffiliation from urban fatigue, disillusionment, and emotional misalignment. They did not necessarily know where they were headed, but they knew they could no longer remain where they were. What unfolded were shifting storylines that juxtaposed urban rupture—marked by burnout, relational pressure, and existential misfit—with rural practices of slowness that reconfigured everyday life.

Ninh had been working in Saigon for two years after completing a marketing degree. She managed to survive financially, but not spiritually. During a 5 a.m. motorbike trip to the outskirts of Da Lat in 2019, she spoke plainly:

“I did earn a living, but the cost of everything was so high that I was left with nothing. What made me want to leave wasn't the money, it was how stiff everything felt. I had no energy left after work, nothing for myself. I wanted to grow, to learn something new: philosophy, psychology, Buddhism ... so many things I still want to explore.”

Ly echoed this sentiment. After graduating from Foreign Trade University and briefly working in Hanoi, she felt stuck in a loop. “I rushed into a job right after college, it was dead boring,” she recalled in a 2022 meeting in Hanoi.

A chance volunteering opportunity at a homestay introduced her to Du, who offered her a managerial role. Ly accepted. “I wanted to try being my own boss,” she said, laughing. “Only later did I realize that ‘being your own boss’ means you don't even get Sundays off.”

Vinh, formerly a logistics and study-abroad center manager, experienced structural collapse in his workplace.

“My company went bankrupt when the economy tanked. I joined another logistics firm, but then it was bought out by a Chinese group. The new bosses squeezed us hard, I couldn't take it anymore.”

Sitting by a pond in Gia Lai in 2023, he added, “People think life in the city means success, status. But it's not stable. A job with a high title doesn't mean a stable life. Life here may pay less, but it's more peaceful, and honestly, it's more financially sustainable than many city jobs.”

Du, trained in medicine, left her field after three years.

“I wasn't bad, but I wasn't great either. More importantly, it wasn't what I loved,” she explained. “When I was young, people said medicine was a good major, so I just followed. But it didn't feel like me.”

She began taking online courses, reading extensively, and became increasingly fascinated by Scandinavian homestay models. “I wanted to burn for something I truly loved,” she said.

The exits were not always tied to professional dissatisfaction. For Thao, born in 1992 and originally from Nam Định, familial expectations formed the most suffocating structure.

“My parents kept telling me to marry. They even sent relatives to meet me in Saigon to talk about settling down,” she recounted.

Despite holding a high-paying job in Hanoi, she relocated to Ho Chi Minh City, hoping for distance. But the pressure followed. Eventually, she saved enough to purchase rural land in Gia Lai. She now lives in a forested enclave far from any town.

“I don't understand why being a 30-year-old woman means I must get married,” she said. “It's not that I refuse marriage, I just haven't met anyone I want to marry. I still want to travel.”

She wears her hair short and dresses androgynously. We often joked she was the type foreign men would find attractive. She would only smile, replying, “I don't care about that. Some things you just can't plan.”

For others, emotional rupture came from relational breakdown. Vinh again: “My life's been one long disaster,” he said one night, his tone neither bitter nor dramatic. “My parents divorced early. My mother raised me alone. We were dirt poor. I worked hard to escape that. But in chasing money, I lost all my time and relationships.”

The final rupture came after his divorce.

“I needed a place to settle my heart.”

When asked if he missed his mother or child, he shook his head.

“My mom prefers living alone. I invited her to stay with me after Japan, she refused. After the divorce, I asked again. She still wanted to be by herself. And my kid, she's fine with my mother. She's strong.”

He leaned back and looked out across the pond.

“All the ups and downs made me see how impermanent life is. Here at the farm, everything is calm. No storms. I can just live simply, do what I enjoy, fishing, photography, chess, a little drink.”

Across these narratives, there is a recurrent motif: refusal. The city is rendered unlivable not through poverty alone, but through rigid routines, relational pressures, and emotional dissonance. For some, it was the suffocation of sameness. For others, the weight of expectation. But in each case, rural relocation was not a homecoming. It was an unplanned flight from places that had begun to consume them.

4.2. *“Staying not to belong, but to become”*

For many participants, staying in the rural setting was not an act of settling. It was not the culmination of a journey toward belonging. Rather, it was a continuation, a moment of pause in an ongoing process of becoming. There were no five-year plans, no definitive claims of permanence. What mattered was the emotional clarity of the present: “This feels right for now.”

Thao had no intention of building a future in the conventional sense.

“I was so tired of everything,” she said quietly. “Then Thanh asked me to come along, and I just left. I didn’t think too much.”

She described her move not as a decision, but as a response, timed by weariness, shaped by coincidence.

“Maybe I’ll stay for a while and then move again. But I still want to have a place that’s mine, something peaceful.”

She once dreamed of living by the sea but found the land too expensive.

“Thanh helped me find this plot. It felt right, so I bought it. Now it’s here if I ever want to come back, no matter where I go.”

Thanh himself was rarely still.

“If I don’t move, I feel like I’ve stopped living,” he said during a late-night conversation in November 2023.

He made no promises to any place. Some months he was gone for over 20 days.

“I never plan too far ahead. When I stay too long in one place, I get restless again. But I miss this place whenever I’m away too long.”

His travels spanned countries, yet he always returned, not out of obligation, but because the farm had become a rhythm in his orbit.

Others also spoke of the farm not as home, but as a momentary alignment. For Ha, the feeling was not about rootedness, but resonance.

“Here, people love me more than my own family ever did,” she said.

She spoke of a kind of emotional shelter, fragile but real.

“No one judges me here. But they care enough. Once, I got sick in the middle of the night, and someone went all the way to the district center to buy me medicine.”

Suong contrasted the atmosphere with other farms she had volunteered at.

“I’ve been to Huế, but people there were strange. They made you perform love, like you had to express gratitude every day, and count your working hours.”

She found the freedom at this farm more genuine.

“Here, everyone just does what they want. We work, sure, but no one forces anything. And no one’s trying to look spiritual.”

She had grown tired of the “colorful masks” in the city.

“City life is already full of pretense. What’s the point of escaping if I have to perform again in some healing retreat in the mountains?”

Her stays were irregular, but intentional.

“I just come when I want to. After Covid, I was sick of work. Maybe I’ll return to Saigon eventually, but even if I do, I’ll come back here every year.”

These stories did not end with resolutions. No one claimed arrival. Their movement was not toward a singular destination, but across multiple in-between moments, each lived as a “right place at the right time.” The farm was not a future. It was a condition of the now: emotionally sustainable, temporally open, and experientially sufficient.

4.3. *Reconfiguring values through affective practices*

Daily acts of labor, brewing coffee, tending gardens, cooking meals, managing farm routines, were not peripheral activities. They formed the core of a new way of being. These practices, while seemingly mundane, offered participants a canvas on which to articulate value beyond credentials, income, or social status. They were not only working; they were healing, sustaining, and becoming.

Thanh, once a logistics manager in the city, found his sense of vitality in the slowness of soil and plant life.

“Manual work strengthens the body. But really, it clears the mind too,” he said in March 2025, wiping his hands on a faded shirt while pointing to a row of newly planted guava trees.

He spoke with calm precision, describing the rhythm of watering the plants, watching them grow.

“I’ve only been here a year. When I first came, the garden was empty. Now I pick guavas in the morning, gather vegetables in the afternoon, and collect eggs for dinner. Soon, I’ll have goats. One step at a time.”

Vinh, formerly the head of a study-abroad center, had shifted to making drinks at a small café on the farm.

“It’s not tiring. It’s not hard. I learned it quickly,” he said with a soft chuckle. “But it’s different from city life, it doesn’t wear you down.”

Though the salary was lower, the pace was lighter, the demands fewer, and the calculations simpler.

“I don’t need to think about deadlines or clients. I just make coffee. People drink it. They smile. That’s enough.”

For several participants, the act of turning away from salaried city jobs was not a failure, it was a refusal. Rejecting marriage pressures, walking away from long-term careers, choosing to grow food rather than chase promotions, these were not escapes. They were modes of reclaiming authorship over one’s time and energy.

Ninh, who had once worked in marketing in Saigon, recalled his early doubts about Du’s farm management style.

“At first, I didn’t agree with the way she ran things,” he admitted. “But then we fell in love, and we started building this place together.”

Now, the satisfaction came not from scale, but from co-creation.

“It wasn’t always easy, but we made something real. Something we own. We do what we love. We live by our own ideas.”

He spoke of success not in terms of growth or expansion, but of alignment, between labor and life, values and action.

Du’s story followed a longer arc of trial and perseverance.

“There were times I wanted to quit,” she said, her voice steady but tired. “The money was tight. Everything felt messy. And my mom kept interfering, even when she said she supported me.”

Running the homestay meant managing staff, hosting guests, troubleshooting logistics, and holding together an intricate web of relationships.

But things shifted when a former volunteer returned, this time as a business and life partner.

“We’ve been doing this together for about three years now. He understands the flow. We share the load. We travel. We grow things at our pace.”

The atmosphere became calmer, the operation more professional. And with it, came a sense of fulfillment.

Her mother’s acceptance of her queer relationship added another layer of affirmation.

“She didn’t resist when I told her. She just said: live your life, but don’t forget to take care of yourself.”

Du smiled when recounting this. It was not a grand gesture of liberation, but it was enough.

These vignettes were not about utopia. Participants still faced exhaustion, conflict, and uncertainty. But within their routines, a different kind of value emerged. There was no need to prove anything to the city, to parents, or to past selves. Instead, meaning came through affective labor: the kind that mends the self, builds connection, and reshapes what matters.

Here, to clean a guest room was to care for a space. To harvest vegetables was to reclaim agency. To sit still in the sun, to fix a leaky roof, to brew a cup of tea, these were all acts of emotional reorientation. In doing so, participants carved new grammars of worth, outside the metrics of resumes, titles, or performance reviews.

They were not seeking permanence. They were seeking coherence. And in these repetitive, embodied gestures of the everyday, they found it. Yet, these capacities to refuse and to sustain slowness were unevenly distributed—participants with education, savings, or access to land were better able to maintain alternative lives, revealing how aspiration was

always entangled with capability.

5. Discussion

The decision to leave the city, for participants in this study, was driven less by an idealized rural pull than by urban burnout and relational/structural pressures. Ninh and Vinh spoke of futile career advancement amid precarious restructuring, while Thao emphasized suffocating marriage expectations. Yet these ruptures also opened space for projects of autonomy, creativity, and self-cultivation—from Buddhist philosophy to communal living. Such accounts align with Benson's (2016) analysis of lifestyle migration as negotiations of emotional belonging and with Osbaldiston et al. (2020), who stress reflexive affect management in migration trajectories. Rather than nostalgic return, these moves recalibrate tempo and meaning, echoing Benson and O'Reilly (2016) view of lifestyle as emergent in practice.

Lifestyle migration studies often highlight “middle-class affluence” (Benson and O'Reilly, 2009) or “economic privilege” (Benson and O'Reilly, 2016) as prerequisites, but Vietnamese cases complicate this framing. Several interlocutors were not securely middle-income yet still relocated, driven by exhaustion and precarity. For participants like Vinh or Ha, rural life—with lower costs and stronger emotional support—offered greater stability than urban employment. Emotion thus emerges not as secondary but as a decisive force, enabling aspirations for self-authorship even under financial insecurity. These narratives also resonate with research on “amenity migration” (Servon and Pink, 2015) and the slow movement (Parkins and Craig, 2006; Osbaldiston, 2013), where leaving the city is framed as deceleration and refusal of capitalist temporalities, even absent sustainability discourse. In sum, crises of work, kinship, and identity converged with aspirations for self-authorship, producing an affective refusal of urban scripts that foregrounds refusal itself as agency.

In rural settings, belonging was enacted through everyday practices of slowness—gardening, cooking, repairing, and sharing meals—that provided affective anchors rather than permanent settlement. These mundane routines offered fragile coherence in the present, echoing Parkins and Craig's (2006) “slow living” and Osbaldiston's (2013) framing of slowness as negotiation within accelerated worlds. Unlike amenity migration cases often tied to sustainability branding or leisure (Servon and Pink, 2015), these practices emerged from existential survival and emotional healing. This supports Benson and O'Reilly (2016) call to view “lifestyle” as an inductive, situated process, while showing how vulnerabilities—burnout, kinship breakdown, and career precarity—shaped Vietnamese youth's affective labor.

Participants' rural lives centered less on permanence than on inhabiting open-ended temporalities, resonating with Antonsich's (2010) “belonging as becoming.” Their narratives reflected an ongoing negotiation of self through pauses, relocations, and provisional attachments, not nostalgic return. Probyn's (1996) view of belonging as desire illuminates this unfinished quality, where desire was often subtractive—a refusal of urban scripts of productivity, heteronormativity, or familial duty. This complicates lifestyle migration accounts that privilege authenticity or aesthetic fulfillment (Benson and O'Reilly, 2016), instead foregrounding coherence achieved through disconnection and experimentation with slower, less legible rhythms of life.

Foregrounding emotional rupture and affective refusal situates Vietnamese youth mobility within the Global South's volatile urbanization rather than affluent retreat contexts. In line with de Haas's (2021) aspiration–capability framework, aspirations here are not only additive but also subtractive—anchored in the capacity to let go of urban scripts and reconfigure life through contingent rhythms. Extending Antonsich's (2010) “belonging as becoming,” belonging emerges through negative affect and disconnection, challenging celebratory accounts of authenticity-seeking in lifestyle migration (Benson and O'Reilly, 2016). Theoretically, this bridges affective mobility scholarship (Glaveanu and Womersley, 2021) with post-urban and slow living literatures (Parkins

and Craig, 2006; Osbaldiston, 2013), showing refusal as a generative practice of life-making.

Practically, the study suggests that youth and rural development policies must recognize existential and emotional motivations alongside economic drivers. Programs supporting rural youth engagement would benefit from offering flexible, non-linear opportunities—such as volunteer models, short-term residencies, hybrid living arrangements, or community-based projects—that respect the plurality of aspirations shaping young people's futures. In education and career guidance, institutions should also recognize alternative life-making strategies, including experiential learning and seasonal mobility, as valid pathways toward well-being and self-authorship. Rather than framing full-time urban employment as the singular benchmark of success, policy and practice should make room for plural aspirations and emotional sustainability, especially in contexts where young people seek to live differently, not merely elsewhere.

6. Conclusion

This study has shown that young Vietnamese move from cities to rural farms not as a nostalgic return, but as an affective response to crisis and aspiration, where urban burnout and relational pressures intersect with desires for autonomy and coherence. In rural life, belonging is enacted through everyday practices of slowness—cooking, caregiving, farming—that create temporary yet meaningful anchors, less about permanence than about living in alignment with the present. Belonging emerges as a process of becoming, where detachment from urban scripts opens space for new forms of self and sociality to take shape. Ultimately, these movements reveal rural relocation as both refusal and experiment: not an endpoint, but an affective tactic for reimagining how life can be lived otherwise in uncertain times. By foregrounding these trajectories, the study contributes to Global South scholarship and adds to global conversations on mobility, belonging, and the search for alternative futures.

CRedit authorship contribution statement

Tran Mai Huong: Writing – review & editing, Project administration, Methodology, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Mai Phuc Thinh:** Writing – original draft, Methodology, Formal analysis, Conceptualization.

Funding acknowledgement

This research received no specific grant from any funding agency in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Acknowledgements

We thank all the young individuals who generously shared their stories and reflections during fieldwork. We are also grateful to our academic colleagues for their feedback throughout the development of this manuscript.

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